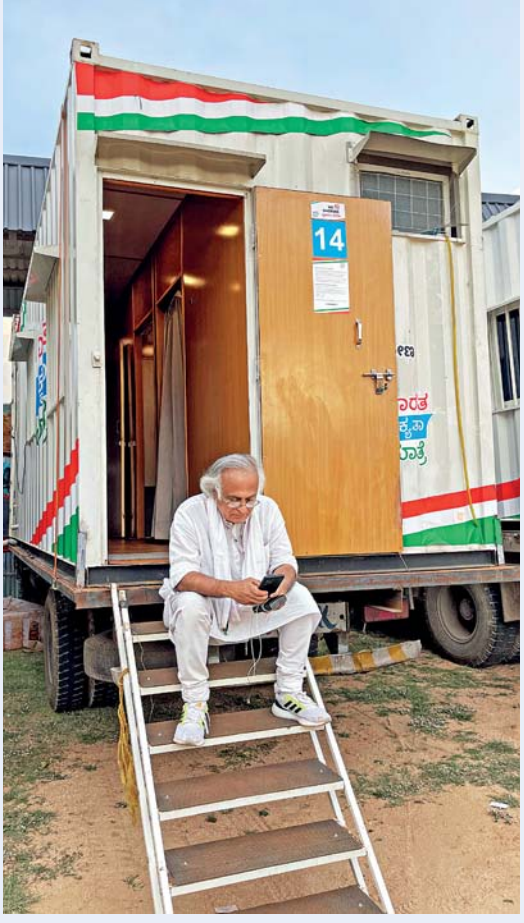
## THE INFRASTRUCTURE

- All yatris spend the night in makeshift containers built on trucks
- 65 containers—60 residential, five for services such as a hospital, conference room, washrooms and electrical unit
- The containers halt at different locations every day—need an area of two acres to park these, erect makeshift dining hall
- Daily breakfast and dinner prepared for 300 people and served in the dining hall
- During the day, temporary camps are set up for permanent yatris and common people to rest and have lunch; three sets of tents keep moving to set up camps well in advance
- Rahul Gandhi rests in a specially designed container van during the day
- Around 40,000 vegetarian lunch meals prepared a day
- 75,000-100,000 packaged water bottles—branded specially for Bharat Jodo—are used daily
- Every container has a load capacity of 20-amp electricity—four gensets of 125 KVA each and two gensets of 65 KVA each are used to supply electricity to the containers
- 12,000 litres of tanker water used daily for cooking, laundry and washrooms in the camp




**PIT STOP**
(From left) Jairam Ramesh outside his container; Container No. 2, for Rahul; the 8-12 bed container





Photographs by KAUSHIK DEKA

**Four types of containers depending on number of beds**

**SINGLE BED**
Container No. 1 and 2—marked yellow, reserved for Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi (when she joins)

**DOUBLE BED**
Marked blue—for top leaders such as Digvijaya Singh and Jairam Ramesh

**FOUR BEDS**
Marked green—for senior state leaders

**EIGHT AND 12 BEDS**
Marked orange—for the rest of the yatris

Political or apolitical? Congress apparatchiks may be chary of conceding the point, but the yatra is clearly about rebranding Rahul Gandhi as the alternative to Prime Minister Narendra Modi. It's about putting some blood and sinew and street cred into the political capital of Rahul. That last thing had been battered by a series of electoral defeats, not to speak of the mammoth BJP machinery fuelling the "Pappu" image, at times aided by Rahul's own inexplicable faux pas.

The BJY comes as a strategic attempt to bust every negative narrative that the BJP has built around Rahul. As the Congress will have a non-Gandhi president on October 19, there's a virtue to be made out of that: Rahul hopes to free himself from the criticism directed at him for the party's electoral failures. "He is a people's man. This is what he enjoys, being among the people, learning from them. Due to security reasons, he has always been kept away from people," says a Congress Working Committee member. A spring in his step, then; also a weight off his shoulders. The yatra has been a platform to showcase Rahul's public connect and present him as a politician with a heart. As the hundreds of cameras travelling with him beam live images, he holds hands with nameless folk as they walk along, comforts a little girl who has fallen down, and engages empathetically with differently-abled individuals waiting to offer him roses. His security contingent tries to stop attempts by people to get too close—policemen use a rope to create a moving barricade around him—but Rahul's eyes are sharp, reaching out to everyone seeking his attention.

Personal attention is given to every *yatri*—there are 122 of them who will walk with him during the day and sleep in the remaining containers at night for the next four months. All of them get a chance to walk and interact with him. If he picks the mind of a doctor from Karnataka on issues related to rural healthcare and telemedicine in India, he engages with a grassroots party worker from Assam on organisational reforms. "I could never have imagined a top leader would spend over an hour with me talking about the party organisation while